

CHAPTER 2: Key Players in the MICE Industry and Their Roles in the Tourism and Hospitality Industry



Key players in the MICE Industry

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Associations

Associations are organized bodies that promote a shared interest or purpose. They are categorized into two main types:

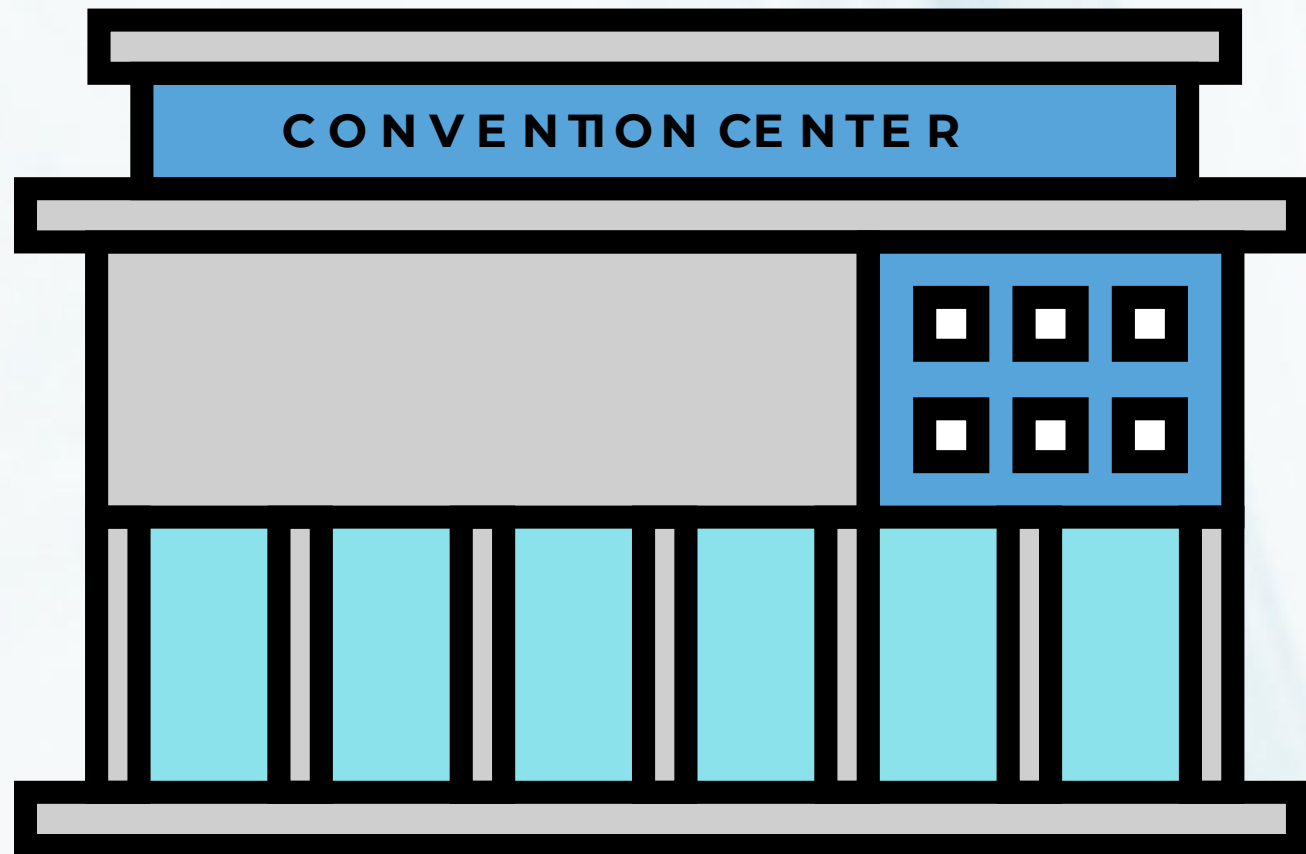
Trade Associations: These are nonprofit organizations that serve the needs of for-profit businesses. An example is the Professional Convention Management Association (PCMA).

Professional Associations: These are also nonprofit but focus on helping members achieve personal and professional goals. They include groups with shared interests (like the AARP), scientific and learned associations (like CHRIE), and religious or charitable organizations (like the American Heart Association).

Both types primarily gather and share information through meetings, seminars, and publications.



Convention Center



A **convention center** is a public agency that hosts meetings and exhibits. These centers provide services such as banquets, food and beverages, and concessions. Most are owned by the city, county, or state government and operated by an appointed board or authority. Some, however, are managed by private companies. Examples of convention centers include the PICC, the Jacob K. Javits Convention Center in New York, and the Anaheim Convention Center in California.

Convention centers offer large, flexible rooms for trade shows, as well as smaller spaces for meetings, banquets, and association events. Historically, these centers were intended to serve the community, but they are now operated as **profit centers**. They generate revenue by renting out their exhibition and meeting rooms, as well as from catering, concessions, and vending. Additionally, many convention centers provide specialized services to exhibitors, such as electrical, telephone, stage construction, lighting, plumbing, and sound services. The marketing of these centers is often assisted by the convention and visitors bureau.

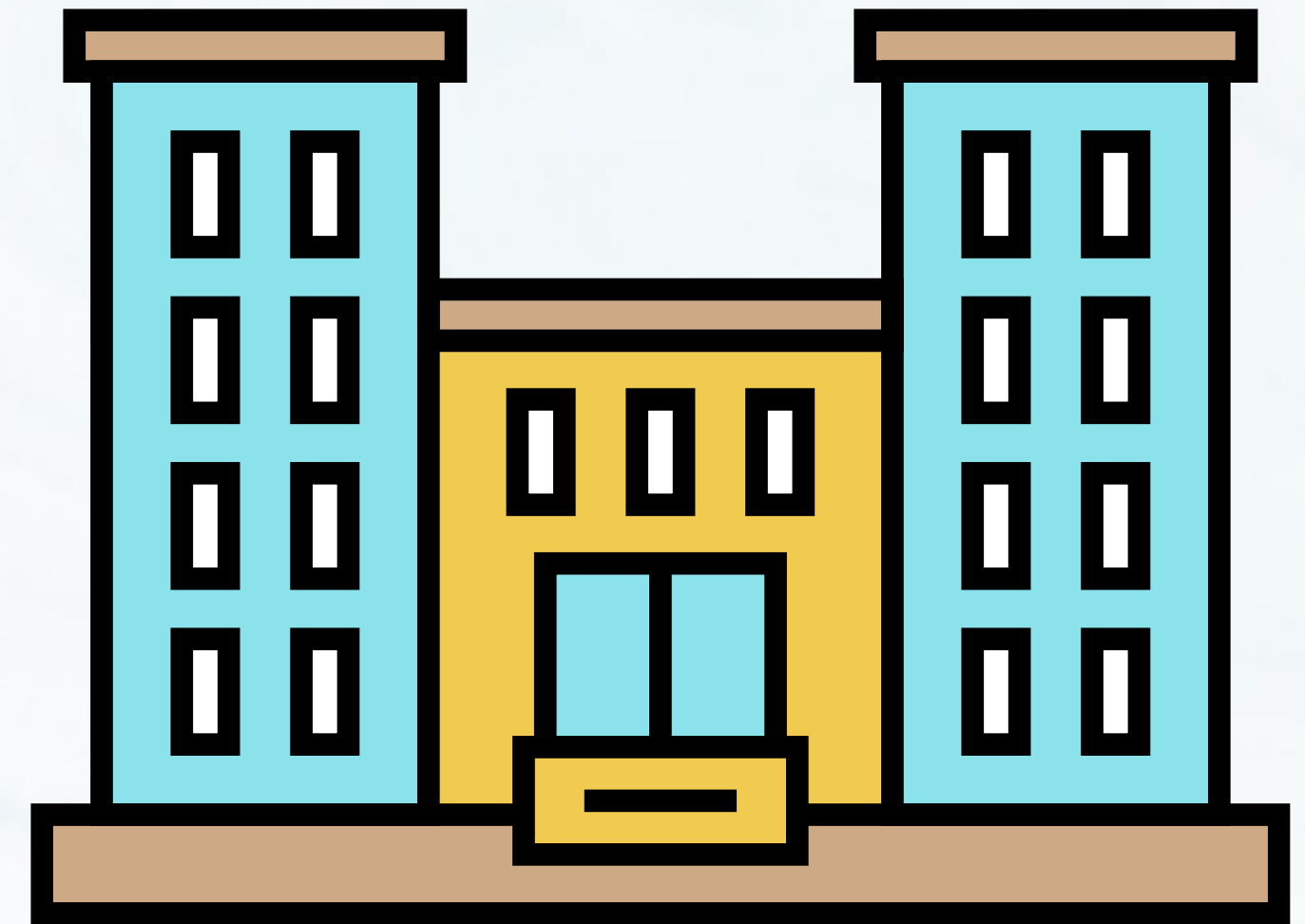
Conference Center

A **conference center** is a specialized hospitality business designed to support small to medium sized meetings of 20 to 50 people. A key feature is that most conference centers offer overnight accommodations for participants, which is a major difference from convention centers. Guests don't need to leave the center during their stay because all their needs including meals, lodging, and leisure activities are provided on site.

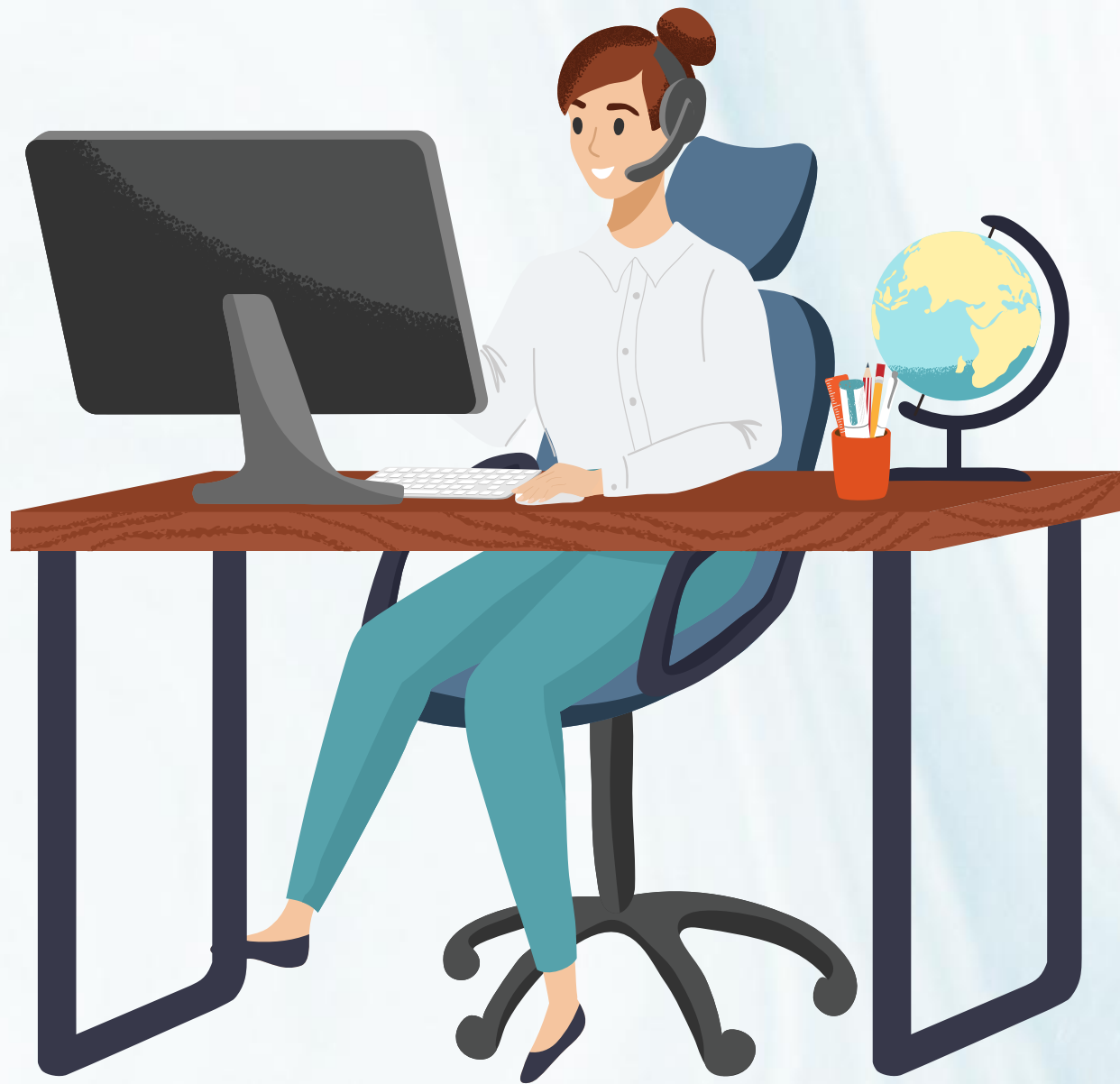
The design of these centers prioritizes **comfort** and **privacy** for attendees. They were created to meet the growing need for specialized meetings. Two unique features of conference centers include:

Continuous refreshment: They provide ongoing refreshments throughout a meeting, allowing attendees to take breaks whenever they want.

All-inclusive pricing: Conference centers charge a single price that covers meals, room rates, meeting rooms, audiovisual equipment, coffee breaks, and paper supplies.



Tour Operators



Tour operators are key players in the MICE industry. They collaborate with meeting planners to arrange tours and activities for meeting attendees and their families. It's a growing trend for delegates to bring their families, and tour operators are becoming more important as a result.

These operators often create tour packages for attendees' spouses, guests, or children. This allows family members to visit local attractions like museums, art galleries, theme parks, or zoos while the delegates are in meetings. Often, delegates receive information about these available tours several weeks before the convention begins.

Trade Shows and Expositions

The terms **trade shows**, **expositions**, and scientific/technical conferences are often used interchangeably within the MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) industry. While historically distinct, with **expositions** being public shows and **trade shows** being private events for industry professionals, Americans have increasingly adopted the term "**exhibition**" to refer to events like art shows. Today, while some trade shows may open to the public on their final day, most remain private. All of these events serve as major marketing forums where industry professionals can exhibit products and exchange information.

Historically, these events evolved from simple meetings. The practice dates back to caravans meeting to exchange goods. In the U.S., a notable early example was Alexander Graham Bell showing the telephone at the 1876 Philadelphia Centennial Exposition. As the industrial era began and individual sales calls became impractical, salesmen started renting hotel rooms to display their products to customers. This evolved into the creation of dedicated exhibit halls, which allowed attendees to move freely between different booths instead of being confined to small hotel rooms.

The trade show industry is a dynamic marketing tool that helps individuals meet their sales goals. Due to the high number of attendees, cities now compete to host these events. The industry involves several key players:

Trade show sponsors are often professional associations that use trade shows as a way to generate revenue.

Exposition or **show managers** are responsible for all aspects of the trade show's operation.

Service contractors provide the necessary services and facilities to run the event.



Hotels



Hotels are vital to the MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) industry, serving as more than just lodging providers. They offer overnight accommodations for event attendees and also provide dedicated spaces such as meeting rooms, convention facilities, and small exposition halls. Events like meetings and conventions have become a major source of revenue for many hotels, with income streams coming from renting out sleeping rooms, providing food and beverage services, and charging for the use of meeting spaces.

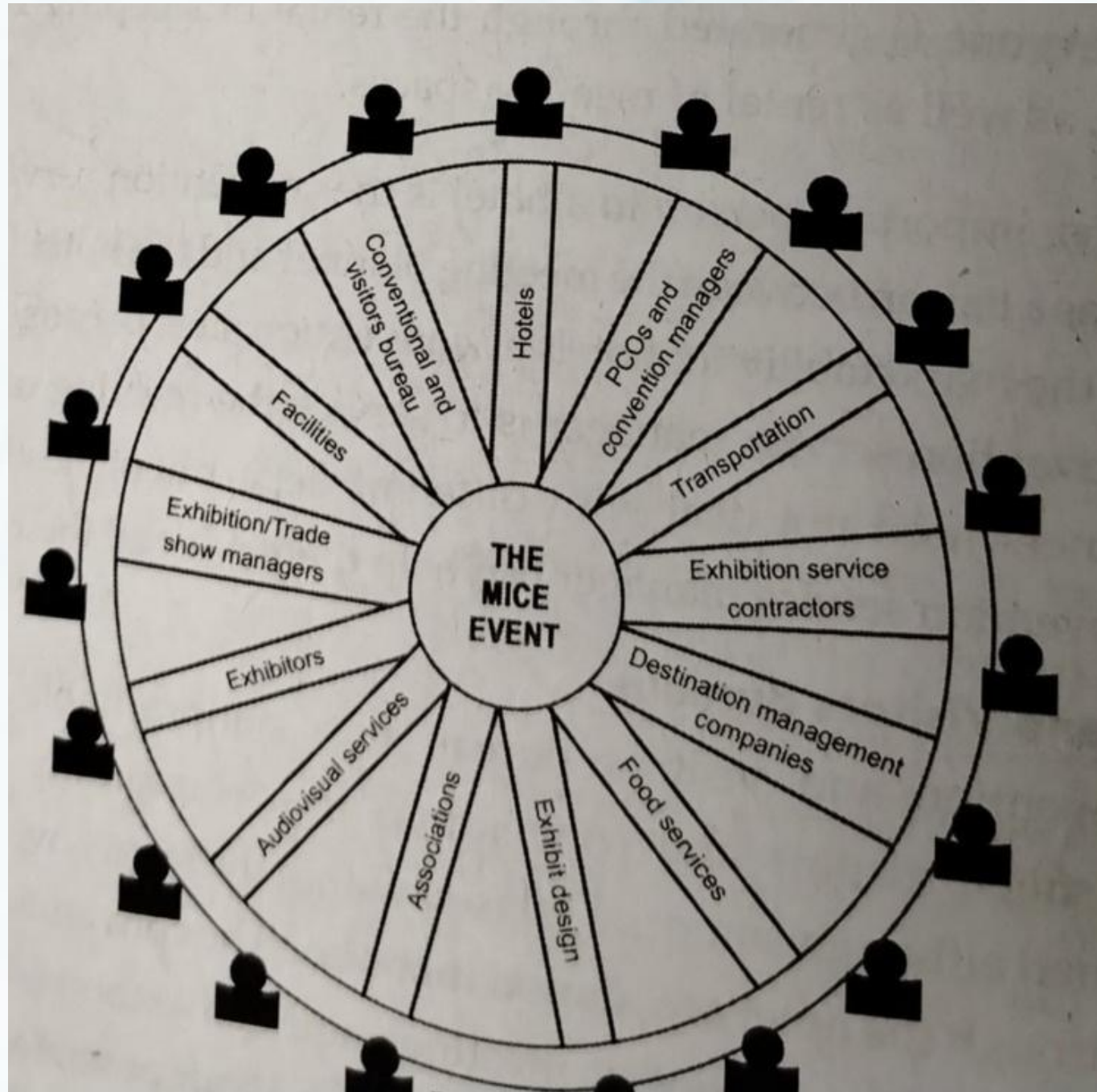
A key figure in this process is the **convention service manager**. This individual acts as a **liaison** between the event's meeting planner and the hotel's various departments. This role is crucial because it significantly boosts a hotel's appeal as an event venue. Instead of having to coordinate with multiple department heads, a meeting planner can simply work through the convention service manager, who handles all their needs and ensures the event runs smoothly. The manager's primary goal is to service the meeting or convention, making the planning process much more efficient for the client.

Convention and Visitors Bureaus

A **convention and visitors bureau (CVB)** is a non-profit organization that works to attract visitors, conventions, and meetings to a specific community. Although some are run by the state government, most are privately owned and funded by a **hotel accommodations tax**. The CVB coordinates all aspects of meetings and conventions, from marketing the location and providing information about potential host facilities to organizing familiarization tours for meeting planners and acting as a link between the group and local suppliers.



The Process of Providing a MICE Event



The **MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) event** is likened to a wheel, with the event itself at the center, managed by a **conference organizer**. The "spokes" of the wheel are the various service **specialists** or **suppliers** (e.g., hotels, transportation, etc.) who provide services for the event. The "rim" of the wheel represents the **delegates** or customers.

Delegates will interact with various suppliers throughout the event, and their overall experience is heavily influenced by these interactions. Therefore, the relationship between each supplier and the delegates is crucial for the event's success. The key players in the MICE industry include hotels, professional congress organizers, convention and visitors bureaus, and other support services.